

Adolf Loos

Austrian–Czech architect Adolf Loos (1870–1933) was an influential theorist of modern design. After a conventional training and a three-year visit to the United States, he gave a lecture in Vienna in 1910 on ‘Ornament and Crime’, in which he attacked decoration in art, architecture and product design. His reputation grew with an essay in the magazine *Cahiers d’Aujourd’hui* in 1913: ‘The evolution of culture marches with the elimination of ornament from useful objects,’ he wrote, explaining that ornamentation – which he labelled ‘immoral’ and ‘degenerate’ – can effectively date buildings and objects. In its place, he advocated smooth and clear surfaces, free of the lavish decorations of art nouveau and the Vienna Secession. ‘Freedom from ornament is a sign of spiritual strength,’ he asserted. Loos’s uncompromising and austere buildings, such as the plain-faced Goldman & Salatsch Building in Vienna (opposite, 1910) – then derided by the staid Viennese as ‘the house without eyebrows’, but now acknowledged as a landmark in *Wiener Moderne* – reflected his pioneering approach.

